

Beyond Talent: How Grit and Growth Mindset Shape Success

Final speech — divided among 6 team members

Target: ~11 minutes total spoken

Team: Musaddik , Jahin, Alhadi Baba, Waseef Munir, Fahad, Mugdho

MUSADDIK — Group Introduction + Opening Hook

(~1.5 min)

Assalamualaikum, everyone.

Today we want to talk about a question most of us have quietly asked ourselves at some point in university: *why do some people seem to get better at hard things, while others stay stuck?*

I'm Musaddik, and this is my team — Jahin, Alhadi Baba, Waseef Munir, Fahad, and Mugdho. Together, we're going to walk you through two ideas that, we think, explain that question better than "talent" ever does.

So let's start with a story.

Imagine two students starting university on the same day.

Student A and Student B.

Same intelligence. Same work ethic. Same grades in their first semester. If you looked at their transcripts, you couldn't tell them apart.

Then, in the second semester, both of them hit something hard. A brutal programming course. A math class that stops making sense. A research project where nothing works.

Student A studies, tries, fails. And a thought creeps in:

"Maybe I'm just not good at this."

That thought changes everything. The difficulty stops being a difficult problem — it becomes evidence about who Student A *is*.

Student B fails too. Same grade. Same mistakes. Same frustration.

But Student B thinks:

"I'm not good at this... yet."

One word. And that word changes the entire story.

Student B asks a friend for help. Reviews the mistakes. Tries again. Fails again. Keeps going.

Fast-forward six months. Same starting point, same opportunities — so why might these two people be in completely different places?

That's the question behind our presentation today:

Is success mostly about how talented you are when you start — or about what you do when things get hard?

ALHADI BABA — The Talent Myth + Introducing Duckworth

(~1.75 min)

We love a simple story about success.

We see someone great at programming and say: "*He's just naturally talented.*" We see someone acing every exam and say: "*She's just really smart.*" We see a phenomenal athlete and say: "*Born with it.*"

And talent is real. People start from different places, with different resources and different opportunities. We're not pretending that's not true.

But talent doesn't explain everything. And that's exactly what psychologist **Angela Duckworth** noticed — not in a lab, but in a classroom.

She taught seventh-grade math in New York City. And she kept seeing something that didn't add up: her strongest performers weren't always her highest-IQ students. Some of her most obviously intelligent kids weren't the ones performing best.

That gap bothered her enough to change her career. She left teaching and became a psychologist, asking one question:

If intelligence doesn't fully explain achievement — what does?

Instead of studying one kind of successful person, she studied wildly different ones: West Point military cadets surviving brutal training. Kids competing in the National Spelling Bee. Teachers thriving in under-resourced, high-pressure schools. Rookie salespeople trying to survive their first year.

Completely different worlds. Same underlying question in every single one: **who keeps going, and who quits?**

One trait kept showing up, again and again, in the people who kept going — regardless of the field.

She called it **grit**. And it became the subject of her bestselling book, *Grit: The Power of Passion and Perseverance*.

[SLIDE CUE: show *Grit* book cover here] (Slide 7)

WASEEF MUNIR — What Grit Actually Is

(~1.75 min)

(Slide 7 continuation)

So let's be precise about what grit actually is — because it's often misunderstood, and honestly, oversimplified.

(Slide 8)

Grit is *not* working hard for one day. It's *not* constant motivation. It's *not* pretending failure doesn't hurt.

(Slide 9)

Duckworth defines it as **passion and perseverance toward long-term goals** — the ability to keep pursuing something that matters, over years, even when the process gets boring, slow, or genuinely painful.

Here's a simple way to separate motivation from grit. Motivation is what you feel on a Sunday night, writing an ambitious study plan, promising yourself six hours of focused work a day. Grit is what's left three weeks later — when the excitement is gone, the material is boring, you just failed a quiz anyway, and nobody's watching to see if you keep going.

Grit asks one blunt question: **can you keep going after the motivation has completely disappeared?**

(Slide 10)

Duckworth has a metaphor for this that captures it perfectly:

"Life is a marathon, not a sprint."

A sprint rewards speed, for a short burst. A marathon rewards something else entirely — the ability to stay in it, mile after mile, long after the adrenaline is gone.

Nobody becomes a strong programmer by solving problems for one intense night. Nobody becomes a great musician from a single five-hour practice session. You get there by showing up again. And again. Long after it stopped being exciting — and long before anyone's applauding you for it.

(Slide 11)

FAHAD — Where Grit Comes From + Fixed vs. Growth Mindset

(~1.75 min)

(Slide 11 Continuation)

So here's a reasonable question: if grit matters this much, can we just tell someone, "*be more persistent*"?

Duckworth's own answer is refreshingly honest: **no**. There's no simple formula — she says so herself, in her own research. Psychology isn't a motivational poster. "Never give up" is not, on its own, a strategy anyone can actually use.

But she does point toward one of the most promising answers we have on this — and it comes from a different psychologist entirely: **Carol Dweck**, and her concept of the **growth mindset**, from her influential book, *Mindset: The New Psychology of Success*.

[SLIDE CUE: show *Mindset* book cover here]

Let's go back to Student A and Student B one more time.

Same failure. Two completely different internal stories.

"*I'm bad at this.*" versus "*I'm not good at this yet.*"

That gap — that one word — is what Dweck calls **mindset**.

A **fixed mindset** treats ability as basically set in stone. You're either good at math, or you're not. Either "a programming person," or you're not. Under a fixed mindset, failure isn't just a bad result — it becomes a verdict on your identity.

A **growth mindset** treats ability as something that develops — through practice, strategy, feedback, and time. Under a growth mindset, failure stops meaning "*I can't.*" It starts meaning "*I haven't learned this yet.*"

MUGDHO — Practical Takeaways

(~1.75 min)

And that single shift changes everything downstream. A hard problem becomes less threatening. A mistake becomes data instead of a judgment. Feedback becomes useful instead of painful. Effort starts to actually mean something.

So, knowing all this — what does it actually mean for us, practically, as university students starting exactly where Student A and Student B started?

Four small shifts, starting today:

One — change the internal sentence. Swap *"I can't do this"* for *"I can't do this yet."*

Two — change the question you ask after failure. Not *"why am I bad at this,"* but *"what did this failure just teach me?"*

Three — don't confuse effort with improvement. If a strategy isn't working, the answer isn't more of the same thing — it's feedback, a different approach, or someone who's already solved the problem you're stuck on.

Four — choose something actually worth the discomfort. Grit isn't suffering for its own sake. It's persistence *in service of something that genuinely matters to you.*

But before we wrap up — there's one honest caveat our team wants to leave you with. Because it would be easy to turn all of this into a motivational cliché, and that's not what good psychology does.

JAHIN — Where the Two Ideas Meet + The Honest Caveat

(~2.25 min)

Here's where *Grit* and *Mindset* actually connect — and it's worth being precise, because they are genuinely not the same thing.

Growth mindset is a belief: "*I can get better at this.*" **Grit** is a behavior: "*I will keep working at it — even now, even today.*"

Belief alone doesn't get you through week six of slow, frustrating, invisible progress. You can genuinely believe improvement is possible and still quit. That's exactly where grit takes over — it's the discipline that keeps showing up *after* the mindset shift has already happened.

Together, these two ideas build a cycle:

Challenge → Failure → Reflection → Learning → Improvement → Confidence → Bigger challenge — and repeat.

Run that loop enough times, and something interesting happens: the person who wasn't very good at something slowly becomes very good at it. And when we meet them at the *end* of that loop, we call them "talented." We don't see the hundreds of failed attempts behind it. We just see the highlight reel — and we mistake it for talent.

But grit and growth mindset are **not a guarantee**. A gritty person can still fail. Someone can work incredibly hard and still fall short — because success depends on more than internal drive. It depends on opportunity, resources, education, support systems, and circumstances that are sometimes completely outside anyone's control. Telling someone from a genuinely disadvantaged situation that they "just need more grit" isn't insight — it can be a way of ignoring the real barriers actually in front of them.

There's one more nuance worth naming clearly: **persistence is not the same as repeating a failing strategy, just harder**. Grinding through the same broken method isn't grit — it's just stubbornness wearing grit's clothing. Real perseverance sometimes means changing the approach, asking for help, or getting honest feedback — not gripping the original plan tighter and hoping.

So grit doesn't mean "*never change your plan.*" It means "*don't give up*

on meaningful progress just because your first attempt failed."

MUSADDIK — Closing

(~1.5 min)

So — let's go back to where we started. Two students. Same ability. Same opportunities. Same first semester.

Then difficulty arrives — and they diverge.

One treats failure as proof of a ceiling. The other treats failure as part of the process.

Talent decided where they *started*. It did not decide where they *ended up*.

Growth mindset changed how they interpreted the struggle. Grit is what kept them in the race long enough for that mindset to actually matter.

Neither one works alone. Both need effort, feedback, the right environment — and sometimes, honestly, a bit of luck.

So maybe the real question isn't "*Am I talented enough to succeed?*"

Maybe it's:

"Am I willing to learn? Am I willing to adapt? And when something actually matters to me — am I willing to keep going?"

Because very often, the person who looks talented at the finish line was simply the person who kept learning long enough for their ability to catch up to their goal.

Talent gives you a starting line. Growth mindset tells you the finish line can move. Grit is what gets you there anyway.

Thank you.

Notes for the group

Timing breakdown (~11 min total):

Order	Speaker	Section	Time
1	Musaddik	Intro + Opening Hook	~1.5 min
2	Alhadi Baba	Talent myth + Duckworth's story	~1.75 min
3	Waseef Munir	What grit actually is	~1.75 min
4	Fahad	Where grit comes from + fixed/growth mindset	~1.75 min
5	Mugdho	Practical takeaways	~1.75 min
6	Jahin	Where the ideas meet + honest caveat (core synthesis)	~2.25 min
7	Musaddik	Closing	~1.5 min

Musaddik speaks twice (open + close) for a combined ~3 min, consistent with leading the team without dominating the middle content. Jahin's section is the conceptual core of the whole talk — the part that actually connects the two books — so it carries the second-longest slot.

Order change from before: Mugdho's "practical takeaways" now comes *before* Jahin's synthesis section instead of after, with a short bridging line at the end of Mugdho's part ("there's one honest caveat our team wants to leave you with") that hands off naturally into Jahin. This was necessary so Musaddik could close — Jahin's section no longer ends the body of the speech, it sets up the close instead of being the close itself.

Slide cues: *Grit* cover lands at the end of Alhadi Baba's section;

Mindset cover lands early in Fahad's section. Both should pause briefly after naming the book title so the slide lands before continuing.

Handoff notes:

- Musaddik → Alhadi Baba: clean, ends on the thesis question.
- Fahad → Mugdho: Fahad ends on the growth-mindset definition; Mugdho opens by extending that same thought ("that single shift changes everything downstream") — practice this one together, it's the tightest handoff.
- Mugdho → Jahin: Mugdho's bridge line sets up Jahin directly — make sure Mugdho doesn't rush past it.
- Jahin → Musaddik: Jahin ends on the caveat/nuance; Musaddik reopens with "let's go back to where we started," which cleanly signals the close is beginning.

Beyond Talent: How Grit and Growth Mindset Shape Success

Slide Content

Slide 1 — Title Beyond Talent: How Grit and Growth Mindset Shape Success

Slide 2 — The Hook Two students. Same intelligence. Same grades. Six months later — completely different outcomes. What happened in between?

Slide 3 — The Central Question Is success mostly about how talented you are when you start — or about what you do when things get hard?

Slide 4 — The Talent Myth "He's just naturally talented." "She's just really smart." "Born with it." Talent is real — but it doesn't explain

everything.

Slide 5 — Angela Duckworth Seventh-grade math teacher, New York City Noticed: strongest performers ≠ highest IQ Question: If intelligence doesn't fully explain achievement — what does?

Slide 6 — The Research West Point cadets National Spelling Bee competitors Teachers in under-resourced schools Rookie salespeople Same question across every group: who keeps going, and who quits?

Slide 7 — Grit (Book Cover) *Grit: The Power of Passion and Perseverance* — Angela Duckworth [Book cover image]

✓ **Slide 8 — What Grit Is Not** Not working hard for one day Not constant motivation Not pretending failure doesn't hurt

✓ **Slide 9 — Defining Grit** Passion and perseverance toward long-term goals Can you keep going after the motivation disappears?

✓ **Slide 10 — The Marathon Metaphor** "Life is a marathon, not a sprint." — Angela Duckworth Sprint: rewards speed Marathon: rewards staying in it

Slide 11 — Can Grit Be Taught? Duckworth's own answer: no simple formula "Never give up" is not a strategy

Slide 12 — Carol Dweck A different psychologist. A different idea. Growth mindset

Slide 13 — Mindset (Book Cover) *Mindset: The New Psychology of Success* — Carol Dweck [Book cover image]

Slide 14 — Fixed Mindset Ability is fixed "I'm either good at this or I'm not" Failure = a verdict on identity

Slide 15 — Growth Mindset Ability develops through practice, strategy, feedback, time Failure = "I haven't learned this yet"

Slide 16 — The Shift Hard problems → less threatening Mistakes → data Feedback → useful Effort → meaningful

Slide 17 — Four Practical Shifts "I can't do this" → "I can't do this yet"

"Why am I bad at this?" → "What did this teach me?" Don't confuse effort with improvement Choose something worth the discomfort

Slide 18 — Where They Meet Growth mindset = a belief: "I can get better" Grit = a behavior: "I will keep working" Belief alone doesn't survive week six

Slide 19 — The Cycle Challenge → Failure → Reflection → Learning → Improvement → Confidence → Bigger Challenge

Slide 20 — The Honest Caveat Grit and growth mindset are not a guarantee Success also depends on opportunity, resources, support, circumstance "Just work harder" can ignore real barriers

Slide 21 — Persistence ≠ Repetition Repeating a failing strategy harder isn't grit — it's stubbornness Real perseverance: change the approach, ask for help, get feedback

Slide 22 — Back to Student A and Student B Talent decided where they started It didn't decide where they ended up

Slide 23 — Closing Thought Talent gives you a starting line Growth mindset tells you the finish line can move Grit is what gets you there anyway

Slide assignments

- **Musaddik:** Slides 1–3, 22–23
- **Alhadi Baba:** Slides 4–7
- **Waseef Munir:** Slides 8–11
- **Fahad:** Slides 12–15
- **Mugdho:** Slides 16–17
- **Jahin:** Slides 18–21